

Becker in Rhetoric Theory and Praxis

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Abstract

This text explores an addition to the rhetoric canon in the form of Ernest Becker's The Denial of Death, a cross-discipline work that tries to understand human motivation through a universal death terror. The work relates Becker to other authors in the contemporary canon, Foucault and Burke, and argues that a focus on exigence through an analytical framework in identification and transference can solve modern problems rhetoric practitioners face, particularly those dealing with information campaigns and counterterrorism described in the collection RHET OPS, edited by Jim Ridolfo and William Hart-Davidson. The final section of the paper acknowledges opportunities for further research that addresses shortcomings of The Denial of Death and contains an annotated bibliography for further reading on the subject.

Introduction

We are in a rhetorical crisis. I don't mean a crisis for persuasive effect, but a real crisis in that our discourses surrounding many of today's greatest problems are bogged down by information campaigns. Despite near unanimous scientific support, science denial still affects how people approach evolutionary biology, vaccination campaigns, and climate change (Brown University). More urgent (although no less important), information operations conducted both by national and extra-national agents have made difficult to discern who exactly is behind the message you're reading, an effect dubbed the *fog of digital rhetoric* (Rodolfo and Hart-

Davidson), leading to a subtle extension of reach for nefarious or extremist organizations across the globe. These are real problems causing real effects influence entirely by unreal things; they're constructed only out of rhetoric and symbols. It would be unfair to call this a new problem, but the scale at which information can be created, shared, and received is incredibly new and incredibly powerful.

Given that these are problems of rhetoric, it is rhetoricians that should solve them... right? In part. The truth is that these very real impacts are being studied by a variety of disciplines and under a variety of names. For every Burke or Aristotle who study rhetoric directly there are multiple Foucaults, Descartes, Bacons, and Derridas that propel the study forward without ever explicitly telling everyone that they're studying rhetoric. It is almost rhetoricians' collective little secret, incorporating works into the canon from outside the discipline whenever we see our subject pop up in philosophy, psychology, and others.

Currently sitting outside of our canon are the works of American cultural anthropologist Ernest Becker, author of many interdisciplinary works that ask the question, "Why do we do what we do?". Through an analysis of early psychoanalyst theories, heroism, and death anxiety, this question resulted in the publication of The Denial of Death, and it is through adding this work to our rhetorical fold that I believe we can both better understand the exigences behind human identifications and better address the rhetorical issues we're facing, particularly in how we can respond to rhetoric operations that are causing immediate harm.

A Brief Overview of The Denial of Death

Although Becker authored many journal articles and several books before it, The Denial of Death represents the refinement and coming-together of much of his earlier work, work that Becker himself admitted was somewhat influenced by the zeitgeist of the times in order to fit in (Becker, *The Ernest Becker Reader* 222). In contrast, The Denial of Death is a more honest and riskier piece that seems to cover the subjects important to Becker, of these being most relevant to the study of rhetoric being Heroism, Death Anxiety, and Transference.

Becker saw Heroism as one of our most basic instincts, the urge to be, do, or build something that will outlast ourselves. Heroism in this way is entirely constructed out of symbols, so much so that Becker acknowledges that all of human cultures are a “symbolic action system, a structure of statuses and roles, customs and rules for behavior, designed to serve as a vehicle for earthly heroism” (Becker, *The Denial of Death* 4). Heroic acts are defined within and by a given culture and it is important to note that most heroics remain so without becoming the high heroism of political, religious, and economic leaders. For most, the “everyday, earthly heroism” is what must suffice, everything from the coal miner providing for their family to the recent college grad getting their first white-collar job and making the next step in their life’s journey. They are heroic not because they are pulling physical coal from the earth or physically changing their daily outfit from an apron to a pressed shirt, but because of the important their culture has imprinted on them as to the value of working hard or moving up in the economic system. Defining heroism leads to the central problem that Becker is trying to cover: how, or even do we ever, become conscious of what we’re doing to earn our heroic feelings (Becker, *The Denial of Death*).

The reason, Becker says, for the importance of heroism is our underlying terror of death. Becker sees that people are actually two different selves, our physical self made of meat and bones and then our symbolic self with all of our cultural identities and urges. Our ability to create the symbolic self leads to a terrifying problem for people: we are simultaneously capable of creating great acts of heroism, from building nations to building space stations, but we are totally aware of our own mortality and subsequent impending demise. “Gods with anuses” (Becker, *The Denial of Death* 51), and this juxtaposition is what Becker feels is the entire cause behind our inability to truly become fully conscious and in control of our own heroism. The risk of failure in our heroic immortality projects is too great for most people. Failing reminds us that we may not be able to make any sort of lasting impression on the world before we die. So for most of us, we don’t embark on our own heroic paths but instead align ourselves with a leaders’ project through transference. We are assimilated into the heroism of the church or the nation or the company or the family. We willingly, if subconsciously, surrender some of our own agency in exchange for being able to be a part of someone else’s greater heroic cause. This process is recasted by Becker from its basic clinical definition in psychology to a greater phenomenon where we are able to tame our existential terror.

Rhetoric In and Around The Denial of Death

While the language isn’t the same language we use in discussing our field, the problems discussed and explored by Becker sound suspiciously similar to the ideas of identity and discourse that we study in rhetoric. Exploring rhetoric from what Becker views as central problems above, rhetoric is how we unite and divide ourselves through the pragmatic truths of

our own heroic projects, how we negotiate the symbolic actions and power structures that allow us to recruit or be recruited into our culture's heroic acts. From this view, transference is no longer a clinical psychological phenomenon but a rhetorical act of persuasion and identity. Most of all, Becker's work helps us analyze the exigence of our discourses through the analytical framework of a hero project.

Particularly relevant to a discussion on Becker are Foucault and Burke, all of whom were active writers during the same time period. Becker's definition of culture, where it governs the values that people place on their heroic actions, can easily be related to Foucault's discourse and statement in Archaeology of Knowledge. The statement is the elementary building block of any particular discourse and has nothing to do with the content within it; the same arrangement of signs in one context can be a statement and not a statement in a different context (Foucault 80). Statement is the relationship that makes the unit applicable and valuable to the discourse and, just like in an archaeologist's excavation, has to do more with context than content. So too are heroic symbolic actions, which can in themselves also be turned into statements. Mining coal is only heroic when surrounded by the discursive elements that make it so: having money is valuable, using money to support a family is rewarded, and so on. Continuing on which Becker's view of culture, a culture's given symbolic action system is dictated by episteme it occurs within. What a group of people know and value must be governed by the "set of relations that unite, at a given period, the discursive practices" that are able to create knowledge (Foucault 191). Different epistemes give way to different values in hero systems.

Like with Foucault, Becker's work can also be connected to Burke's writings on Identification and Consubstantiality, particularly in how it relates to the subject of transference. A core part of Burke's New Rhetoric is its emphasis on identity in persuasion, that what traits

and qualities we identify a person with will affect to what degree we achieve consubstantiality with them (Burke 55). Becker also addresses this subject using different words. The leaders that we join in their heroic projects are not unique in their biology, they are “still *Homo sapiens*, standard vintage” (Becker, *The Denial of Death*). What makes them so powerful is subjective and exists entirely within our symbolic identification of them. This identification can become so profound because, in Becker’s view, we have transferred our own heroic projects into their vision. This can be seen when leaders suddenly pass, an event quickly followed by mourning on national scales. When the leader we identify with goes, we feel as though our own heroic project is in doubt. “Immediately men begin to rename city streets, squares, airports with the name of the dead man: it is as though to declare that he will be immortalized physically in the society, in spite of his own physical death”. The identification that occurs cares more about the rhetorical symbol of the leader than the body itself.

Rhetoric of Heroic Identification in Information Operations

Becker’s concept of heroic transference leads to the mostly unspoken negotiation of identification. While identification is a normal and constant process, it can sometimes go completely awry in our societies. Becker used the manson family as an example, “Here was a group of young men and women who had identified with Charles Manson and who lived in masochistic submission to him. ... To his followers his vision seemed like a heroic mission in which they were privileged to participate.” (Becker, *The Denial of Death* 136). Terrorism is another tragedy of identification, where individuals are convinced that the identifying differences between themselves are so severe that the only solution is threats and violence. We see the same

levels of xenophobic identification in extremist wahabists as we do in the self-identified “involuntary celibate” mass shooters that claim minority immigrants are part of a great conspiracy to replace Europeans in society. These are just as much the same as the German view towards the Jews, Romani, disabled, and gay members of their community; all of the aggressors believed that they found distinctive properties in another group of people that invalidated any claims of consubstantiality they might have had. A passage by Becker helps show this process of identification:

“When we are young we are often puzzled by the fact that each person we admire seems to have a different version of what life ought to be, what a good man is, how to live, and so on. If we are especially sensitive it seems more than puzzling, it is disheartening. What most people usually do is to follow one person's ideas and then another's depending on who looms largest on one's horizon at the time. The one with the deepest voice, the strongest appearance, the most authority and success, is usually the one who gets our momentary allegiance; and we try to pattern our ideals after him. But as life goes on we get a perspective on this and all these different versions of truth become a little pathetic. Each person thinks that he has the formula for triumphing over life's limitations and knows with authority what it means to be a man, and he usually tries to win a following for his particular patent. Today we know that people try so hard to win converts for their point of view because it is more than merely an outlook on life: it is an immortality formula.” (Becker, *The Denial of Death* 255)

An immortality formula. Through this lens, we can see just how important and urgent identification is. Kruglanski et al. use heroism and quests for personal significance to help understand suicide bombers. “Personal traumas, and frustrations, represent a significance loss, motivating the quest for significance restoration. Often, however, it is beyond the power of the

individual to restore her or his lost sense of personal significance.” (Kruglanski, Chen and Dechesne 348). The authors attribute a collectivist shift wherein an individual’s powerlessness can be overcome through identification with a terrorist ideology. Once again, the symbolic action becomes more significant than the physical action, in this case being the ultimate loss of life in service of a cause. I am not glorifying neither the Mansons nor suicide bombers when describing them as heroic. Heroic, as we discussed, occurs within a specific lens and culture. The implications are that exigence and motivation are how to stop these tragic events from occurring before they start, a process known in the counterterrorism community as stopping it “left of the bang”.

Part of interdicting threats left of the bang involves stopping recruitment and identification before it starts. Symbols provide the vocabulary for self-identification (Burke 18) and we haven’t taken seriously enough the ability of asymmetric groups to use rhetorical identification in support of recruitment for their cause. For example, ISIS had a message that appealed to their specific audience in timely updates on the state of the fight and in religious reasoning and storytelling (Maricellino and Magnuson). Their rhetorical effectiveness was effective enough to be effective in discursively attacking on the United States and its allies despite lacking the volume and physical productivity of their actions. Once properly convinced, terrorists and ISIS fighters are now focused on the immortality of their cause and their concept of identification is total. By adding Becker and Burke into an analysis of these messages, it is possible to better analyze the discourse taking place from the perspective of the individual committing the acts. They themselves are the hero in their story and in their community, and combating them on a traditional battlefield only reinforces the idea that their symbolic, heroic action is more valuable than their life. Said best by former President Barack Obama, “Ideologies

are not defeated with guns; they're defeated by better ideas – a more attractive and more compelling vision.”

Addressing Problematic Aspects of Becker and Rhetoric

In order to incorporate Becker into the canon, we first must address some of the problematic and dated aspects of his work. The first is his attitude towards women which, while not explicitly derogatory, does not fit in with our modern view of feminism. Take this quote from his Psychology Today interview in response to a statement from the interviewer that women had an option for immortality projects in the form of childbirth that men don't:

“A book is such a shallow phenomenon compared to a child, isn't it? And it is such a transient heroics compared to a baby. I don't know about my work. I think there is an awful lot of femininity in it in terms of the kinds of things I had to feel in order to write. When it comes to the drive toward heroism, I think men are more competitive than women. The whole drama of history is the story of men seeking to affirm their specialness. One war after another has been caused by the efforts of man to make the world into something it can't be. And look at the energy we put into symbolic pursuits. You just can't imagine a feminine Bobby Fischer with that fantastic, energetic devotion to a symbolic game like chess.” (Becker, *The Ernest Becker Reader* 226)

Not malicious, but certainly not in our modern understanding of gender equality, where we might attribute the heroics of childbirth to be shared rather than an expected burden of a mother. I bring this quote up because it is problematic, but that does not mean that the entire work need be thrown out. I think we can accept that many of those in the rhetorical canon were

problematic in some ways, from sexism to Heidegger being a Nazi. Because of the overwhelmingly male bias of many of these works, there is an opportunity for feminist scholars to add to the discussion of heroism in a way that allows us to fit it into our modern understanding of it.

Dixon writes about the expectations placed on her as a military spouse, and how her expected role in that community is as a “force multiplier” to the heroic actions of the soldier, transferable all the way to the military and the nation as a whole. This expectation is obviously unfair and there is an entire subculture of rebellious spouses in the military that use rhetoric to assert their own identities without being assimilated into the greater narrative (Dixon 242). Becker does touch on this subject when he talks about the specific problems women face in transference on how “almost everyone consents to earn his immortality in the popular ways mapped out by societies everywhere” (Becker, *The Denial of Death* 170). If the popular way of a society is for women to help men in their heroic visions, then a critical understanding of how it happens can help change that societal view writ large through acts of social rebellion, a creative and personal solution to heroism that more adequately incorporates the agency of marginalized groups.

Conclusion and Outlook

Studying the concepts of Heroism and Transference is not only relevant to rhetoric studies but is a valuable framework through which practitioners can understand and tackle real world issues of information campaigns. Becker is not without its problems; even though he denigrates Freud through most of the work, there is still a male focus that needs to be sorted out

by modern writers on the subject. It is worthy criticism, but I feel that despite this effect, the overall framework of using heroic transference to understand the exigence behind modern problems is something that should be isolated, analyzed, and added to our greater map of the rhetorical canon.

The example of using terrorism is only one example, and while I cannot touch on it in this work yet, I feel that using Becker's framework might also explain why it is so hard for science deniers to admit defeat, and instead bunker down when confronted about their beliefs in the face of all evidence. If identity is tied to our very core motivation, death anxiety, and our beliefs are a part of our identity, then that changes the way we need to be tackling the losing rhetorical battle that the internet has enabled. We cannot begin to explore these problems without some sort of call to action to have new scholars begin to deconstruct the works. There is an opportunity for a greater synthesis of Becker and psychoanalysis as a whole in the study of rhetoric, and it is potentially through this critical analysis of exigences that we might become better prepared to tackle the modern problems facing rhetoricians today.

Appendix: Annotated Bibliography

Becker, Ernest. *The Denial of Death*. New York: Free Press, 1973. Print.

The *Denial of Death* is an interdisciplinary exploration of how humans reconcile our powerful symbolic selves with the awareness of our biological realities and weaknesses. Becker synthesizes the early psychoanalytic authors of Freud and Rank with more modern understandings of Psychology, Philosophy, and Cultural Anthropology to pose a potential explanation to the role of death in our lives. Although dated in tone, the work is an incredible synthesis that covers the subjects of cultural heroism, transference, and the psychological terror of death. Without ever explicitly talking about rhetoric, the work dances with the idea of rhetoric in the way we negotiate our life's meaning to ourselves and others. The discussion in transference and leadership in particular shows how our culture's values dictates what types of heroic projects we find worthy and how we either convince others to join our own heroic project or are convinced ourselves into theirs.

The opening chapter of the book introduces the concept of heroism, the idea that we attribute value to our actions in ways that will make a meaningful impact in our society after we die. Becker describes our cultural hero-systems as natural, ubiquitous, and steeped entirely in symbolic actions; addressing and deconstructing these systems is "dealing with *the* universal human problem". This section of the book explains the exigence and Kairos of the rest of the work. Becker references symptoms of what he calls a "modern crisis", symptoms such as the Manson family, Hitler's Germany, and the rampant piling up of money and privileges in both capitalist and Soviet ways of life. Like Chapter One, Chapter Two sets up one of the key concepts of the book, in this case that the terror of death is the "worm at the core" of human anxieties. This chapter is the first

chapter that deals heavily with psychoanalytic concepts and can largely be skimmed over when discussing only the rhetorical implications of death anxiety. The section “The ‘Disappearance’ of the Fear of Death” makes the most important points in briefly recapping repression and arguing that our major childhood anxieties are repressed rather than go away as we age. The rest of the book oscillates between a deep discussion of early psychoanalytic thinkers, including Freud, Rank, Jung, synthesized with philosophers such as Kierkegaard, Nietzsche, Augustine, Kant, and Marx.

—. *The Ernest Becker Reader*. Ed. Daniel Liechty. Seattle and London: The Ernest Becker Foundation in association with The University of Washington Press, 2005.

This compilation contains a collection of readings from Becker that include segments of articles, books, and posthumous notes. *Part Three: Denial of Death as Interpretive Organizing Principle* is the most relevant to the discussion and fills in gaps from The Denial of Death and includes the famous 1974 interview with Becker from his death bed.

In a death-bed interview with Sam Keen, *A Conversation with Ernest Becker*¹ contains Becker’s last reflections on his works. He is open about criticizing some of his earlier work as trying to fit in with the times but offers some final thoughts on heroism that is unconstrained by that earlier need. Excerpts from an unfinished work, *Escape From Evil*, add to the discussion by talking about the exigence of scapegoating, a topic only more relevant in the 1940’s than it is today. Outside of Part 3, Chapter 4 on Alienation ties in

¹Although not cited in this work, Sam Keen discusses his conversation with Becker in a video that can be watched here: <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=-7FaWj9i9XI>

with contemporary authors Baudrillard and Debord, commenting on the psychological impact of issues suspiciously similar to those of Debord's Society of the Spectacle.

Burke, Kenneth. *A Rhetoric of Motives*. Berkeley and Los Angeles: University of California Press, 1969. Print.

Rhetoric of Motives is the second of an intended trilogy that introduces two key concepts used in this paper. The first is consubstantiality, the state of having commonalities with other actors, and identification, the state of seeing oneself as alike in one or more properties.

Burke's piece on consubstantiality and identification is the main vehicle through which I connect Becker's analysis of transference to the study of rhetoric. Both Burke and Becker come to the same conclusion as to the cause of human conflict: our identification with what makes us apart from one another rather than what makes us the same. Burke's ethos in rhetoric studies allows connected pieces a much more solid ground when considering studying in rhetoric. To further strengthen the connection, Burke's discussion on tragic ends also puts an emphasis of death as a means to analyze life.

Dixon, Elise. "Military Wives as Rhetorical Insurgents: Resisting Assimilation as 'Force Multipliers'." Rodolfo, Jim and William Hart-Davidson. *Rhet Ops: Rhetoric and Information Warfare*. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2019. 233-245. Print.

Dixon's piece gives insight into the ways overwhelmingly female military spouses are co-opted into the war effort as "Force Multipliers". The piece addresses how spouses are rhetorically rebelling against these metanarratives despite being often expected to give up their own agency in favor of being used as support staff for the military member they're married to.

Dixon's inclusion into this piece helps address a problem that I don't feel has been adequately covered by other authors, and that's how gender inequality leads to an expected subservience to male heroic projects. Dixon shows examples of official publications that paint military wives to be the second half of a soldier, including an official reading list that puts special emphasis on supporting wounded servicemembers. Notably, military wives are not compensated in any way for the valuable support they give while often having to give up their own careers to play single parent during long servicemember deployments and trainings. Dixon's examples are incredibly important in bringing discussions of heroism into the modern age and how digital rhetoric can help marginalized communities establish their own heroic identities.

Foucault, Michel. *The Archaeology of Knowledge and The Discourse on Language*. Trans. A. M. Sheridan Smith. New York: Pantheon Books, 1971. Print.

Foucault's Archaeology of Knowledge introduces its titular concept as a way of critically examining the way we interact with discourses through the subconscious effect of power differences between us. The term archaeology is used to describe Foucault's specific way

of analyzing discourses based on the context through which they're found, much in the same way archaeologists study artifacts based on their context.

Core to the discussion of Becker is the introduction of Foucault's episteme, a temporal set of relations that governs how a discourse can be interacted with. The concept of the episteme can be applied to what society deems valuable as a heroic work. The work is indispensable in the way it explores what makes a statement in a discourse meaningful by using the concept of a grid of specification, the systems by which symbols in specific orders and occurrence are associated with each other to make meaning. Like most scholars that rhetoricians study, Foucault avoids using the term 'rhetoric' and instead focuses on the idea of the discourse, or ongoing conversations laden with power. Bringing in other scholars who are not explicitly rhetoricians talking about rhetoric helps shore up ethos deficiencies that would otherwise be present when discussing Becker.

Kruglanski, Arie W., et al. "Fully Committed: Suicide Bombers' Motivation and the Quest for Personal Significance." *Political Psychology* Vol. 30, No.3 (2009): 331-357

The authors in this text explore the motivation behind suicide bombers in both an epistemic and pragmatic way that shows these acts as a quest for personal significance. Despite how the actors will no longer live to see their accomplishments, these actions are described as heroic in the eyes of the actor and their communities.

Kruglanski et al. help bring the discourse about heroism from the world of theory to the world of praxis. Suicide bombers are a real-world phenomenon that can be directly attributable to concepts of heroism, and the authors cite Becker as part of their synthesis

explaining a human need for personal meaning that can be more powerful than one's physical needs. In addition to tying Becker to real-world applications, the authors include rhetoric in the discourse by discussing the specific persuasive elements that suicidal militants embrace, regardless whether the militants themselves wrote the piece or not.

Maricellino, William M. and Madeline Magnuson. "ISIS Versus the United States: Rhetorical Battle in the Middle East." Rodolfo, Jim and William Hart-Davidson. *Rhet Ops: Rhetoric and Information Warfare*. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2019. 125-141. Print.

This text compares the effective discursive warfare occurring between the United States and ISIS using token analysis of a two corpora, the first being US Government discussion about ISIS and the second being an Arabic corpus of ISIS's public talk. It shows that there are more similarities than differences in the effectiveness of these pieces and that looking at volume isn't enough of a metric to study rhetorical effectiveness.

This piece shows a more quantitative picture of qualitative analysis concerning the ability for one party to be able to effectively spread the messages concerning their cause. The specific outcomes show that rhetorical agents much less powerful than another can still be effective using multipliers of the internet and cultural acceptance of a message. It effectively helps to show that the

Rodolfo, Jim and William Hart-Davidson. "From the Dark Side of Digital Composing to

#RhetOps." Rodolfo, Jim and William Hart-Davidson. *Rhet Ops: Rhetoric and Information Warfare*. Pittsburgh: University of Pittsburgh Press, 2019. 2-18. Print.

Rodolfo and Hart-Davidson explain the exigence behind their book and the current stakes that relate to modern rhetoricians. They explain the need for rhetoricians that are trained in understanding the phenomenon of digital operations that are happening and may only increase in severity as machine-learning takes greater control of our language.

The introduction effectively sets the emotional stage for the rest of the articles in the book and shows how violence is increasingly being used as a message. They clearly show their expertise in the subject, both on a personal level and in their awareness of the discourse surrounding #rhetops in the modern digital battlefield. They point to two broad themes that are impacting our communities today in digital spaces: "the increased interest in digital rhetoric by military organizations and the use of machine-learning and nonhuman agents in digital networks".